

Ambiguity, Eclipses, and Hidden Power in *Paradise Lost* and León

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An eclipse does not distinguish the light of the sun, it obscures it for a brief yet incredibly powerful moment. While God is often described as all-encompassing, Satan reveals the divide between what is and what could be. The entire kingdom of Leon, including the massive bright León Cathedral, known as the House of Light, will soon be shrouded in twilight as the Moon moves in front of the Sun for a brief moment in time. This distinction between extinguishing a source and temporarily obstructing it is what Milton communicates in Book I of *Paradise Lost*, in the six lines where he compares the newly fallen Satan to the Sun "shorn" of its beams by the intervening Moon (594–599). Milton had darkness available to him as a metaphor for defeat—in the forms of night and shadow—but he chose an eclipse specifically, a phenomenon in which the light source persists, unseen but intact behind the object blocking it. That choice is the argument of this essay: in *Paradise Lost* (594–599), eclipse imagery does not signal Satan's total defeat. It conveys a transitional, obscured strength that unsettles because the reader knows the massive powerful Sun behind the Moon has not left. This tension between a brilliance you know is there and a phenomenon that obstructs it resembles something I experienced watching León Cathedral afar from a rooftop terrace one evening. As the day turned to night, one side of the cathedral was not lit up like the rest. This side of the Cathedral was dimmed to a dark grey, still standing tall, blacklist against the illuminated side, with its towering pyres only visible enough to distinguish its presence.

Milton's language in these lines avoids the idea that Satan has simply gone dark. The sun is "shorn of his beams": not destroyed or removed, but cropped, the way wool is cropped from a sheep that remains entirely itself underneath. The image insists that what is lost is visibility, not underlying substance. Milton reinforces this with the "horizontal misty air" through which the light must pass: mist is not an absence of

light but a medium that bends and filters it, an illusory phenomenon rather than a wall. Satan is not extinguished by his fall and retains a residual majesty. His glory has been transformed in a different direction rather than erased, and it is this remaining power that keeps him dangerous.

The syntax of the following lines builds a complimentary sense of being caught between two states rather than committed into either one. "Dim eclipse" gives way to "disastrous twilight," a phrase etymologically rooted in dis-astron—with dis meaning an ill condition combined with astron meaning star—and "twilight" names neither day nor night but the transitional period between them. Where total darkness might at least offer the relief of finality, this half-visible twilight is active. It "sheds" itself onto "half the nations," an ongoing, spreading event rather than a completed one. The effect on the reader resembles the effect described within the poem, disorientation produced by an ambiguity that keeps shifting.

That ambiguity disrupts an entire political system in the final section. The eclipse brings "fear of change" and "perplexes monarchs": verbs that position the danger not in darkness itself but in what darkness makes possible. A sky gone suddenly ambiguous threatens kings since uncertainty is the precondition for chaos or upheaval. An obscured power is more destabilizing than an absent one, since no one can be sure exactly what it still commands. The deeper logic of this passage is that transition requires an edge, a visible boundary where light meets shadow, and it is that edge—not darkness on its own—that creates fear.

I felt a version of this transition another night walking outside León Cathedral. The building is sometimes called the Pulchra Leonina, the "House of Light," for the enormous stained glass windows that flood its interior with saturated color on a clear day. I have walked past it most days here in León and witnessed its brilliance in full illumination. But one evening, as the day turned to night and clouds of smoke from surrounding wildfires settled over the sky, I watched the House of Light lose its sunlit color. The cathedral hadn't changed. Its brilliance and its capacity to fill a room with color were still there, waiting behind temporary clouds of smoke. What had changed was only what reached me at that moment. I started

thinking about the brilliance I couldn't currently see rather than the darkening exterior in front of me — which is, I feel, the effect Milton is describing in *Lost Paradise*.

Lost Paradise and the *House of Light* reveal a message: that obscured power is more unsettling than absent power, because it asks the participant to observe two things at once—what is visible now, and what they know is still there, waiting on the side opposite the source of light.